



A WORKER unloads corn at a processing center in Misantla, Mexico. “Corn is Mexico,” President Claudia Sheinbaum declared recently. HECTOR QUINTANAR Bloomberg

Don’t mess with Mexico’s maíz, a constitutional amendment declares

Corn is central to the national identity. No genetically modified seeds will be permitted.

By KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — There’s a popular saying in Mexico, where corn is as central to national mythology as it is gastronomy. *Sin maíz, no hay país.* Without corn, there is no country.

This week, Mexico’s leaders voted to enshrine that concept in the Constitution, declaring native corn “an element of national identity” and banning the planting of genetically modified seeds.

The measure, which aims to protect Mexico’s thousands of varieties of heirloom corn from engineered versions sold by American companies, has become a nationalist rallying cry. Support for the reform has only grown in recent months as Mexico has fended off insults, threats of tariffs and even the specter of U.S. military intervention from President Trump.



CORN WAS BORN in Mexico about 9,000 years ago, when Mesoamerican farmers started to domesticate the wild grass known as *teosinte*. It has been revered ever since. GERARDO VIEYRA NurPhoto

“Corn is Mexico,” President Claudia Sheinbaum said recently, describing the reform as a way to secure Mexico’s sovereignty. “We have to protect it for biodiversity but also culturally, because corn is what intrinsically links us to our origins, to the resistance of Indigenous peoples.”

The amendment to the Constitution comes after the defeat in December of a related effort that sought to phase out all imports of genetically modified corn. Then-President Andrés Manuel López Obrador issued a presidential decree in 2023 banning the use of genetically engineered corn in dough and tortillas and for animal feed and industrial use, but a trade dispute panel ruled that it violated the U.S.-Mexico-Canada Agreement.

Mexico agreed to abide by the panel’s ruling, and this week’s action targets seeds, not all products.

The amendment received the last approval needed from [See Mexico, A4]

AI startup’s chatbot is risk to children, parents say in lawsuits

Menlo Park firm and others face scrutiny as tech rapidly expands.

By QUEENIE WONG

When her teen with autism suddenly became angry, depressed and violent, the mother searched his

phone for answers.

She found her son had been exchanging messages with chatbots on Character.AI, an artificial intelligence app that allows users to create and interact with virtual characters that mimic celebrities, historical figures and anyone else their imagination conjures.

The teen, who was 15

when he began using the app, complained about his parents’ attempts to limit his screen time to bots that emulated the musician Billie Eilish, a character in the online game “Among Us” and others.

“You know sometimes I’m not surprised when I read the news and it says stuff like, ‘Child kills parents

after a decade of physical and emotional abuse.’ Stuff like this makes me understand a little bit why it happens. I just have no hope for your parents,” one of the bots replied.

The discovery led the Texas mother to sue Character.AI, officially named Character Technologies Inc., in December. It’s one of two

lawsuits the Menlo Park, Calif., company faces from parents who allege its chatbots caused their children to hurt themselves and others. The complaints accuse Character.AI of failing to put in place adequate safeguards before it released a dangerous product to the public.

[See AI backlash, A10]

California immigrant healthcare at risk of cuts

State Democrats face pressure to roll back coverage as costs rise \$3 billion over budget.

By TARYN LUNA

Gov. JB Pritzker proposed a \$330-million budget cut last month to scale back an expansion of healthcare coverage for undocumented adult immigrants in Illinois, where a state audit found that services for certain age groups exceeded cost estimates by more than 280%.

California Democrats are facing the same financial pressure to reduce coverage during a budget crunch.

California became the first state in the nation to offer healthcare to all income-eligible immigrants one year

ago, which gave Gov. Gavin Newsom another liberal achievement to tout when lauding the Golden State as a national trailblazer.

But the \$9.5-billion price tag of California’s program is already more than \$3 billion above the budget estimate from last summer and is expected to grow even higher.

“We should not bear these costs. Period. But especially in a budget crisis,” said Assemblymember Carl DeMaio (R-San Diego).

California’s expansion of healthcare coverage for all residents, regardless of immigration status, has made the state a ripe target for conservatives as President Trump pushes a nationalist agenda in Washington, which includes his aggressive push for deportations.

[See Healthcare, A6]



MATIAS SANCHEZ watches Juana Dominguez hand out pamphlets on Medi-Cal, the state’s Medicaid program for low-income residents including immigrants. WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

Reeling from Trump’s tariff tumult

California businesses struggle to keep up with ever-changing trade conditions.

By ANDREA CHANG AND SANDRA McDONALD

Tariffs haven’t yet hit the supply chain at Anawalt in Malibu, but the hardware store and lumber seller is bracing for steep price hikes in the coming weeks.

The majority of the lumber that the store sells comes from Canada and nearly all of its steel products are made in China, general manager Rieff Anawalt said. Those countries, along with Mexico, have been targeted in sweeping tariffs imposed by President Trump during his second term, sparking a global trade war that intensified this week.

“These tariffs are 100% going to impact us,” Anawalt said. Wholesale reps for the family-run hardware company, which has five locations around Los Angeles County, have warned him to expect prices to go up by April 1 — costs that he said he’ll have to pass on to customers.

“We’re going to see major increases: 15% to 25% across the board in this industry,” he said. “It’ll make COVID prices seem cheap.”

Across California, businesses of all kinds — farmers, automakers, home builders, tech companies and apparel retailers — are reeling from weeks of on-again, off-again tariff chaos as Trump has announced a slew of levies against the country’s top three trading partners, implementing some while modifying, delaying or reversing others.

“It’s a day-by-day soap opera, and just like a soap opera, you get relief, then it heats up again,” said Jonathan D. Aronson, a professor of international communication and international relations at USC.

As a result, business owners “don’t know what’s going to happen,” he said. “They can’t plan. They don’t know how much to produce. They don’t know who their business is.”

[See Tumult, A8]

Spending bill averts shutdown

Resolution to fund government through September draws some reluctant Democratic votes. **NATION, A5**

A possible win for State Farm

Insurer gets provisional approval for a rate hike, after a rejection last month. **BUSINESS, A7**

U.S. investigates 52 campuses

Three UC and Cal State universities are among those accused of race-based discrimination. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Sunny and warmer. L.A. Basin: 64/45. **B8**

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